Mappilas had been joined by other Muslims, known locally as Pardesi, or ‘strangers’. The Portuguese Duarte Barbosa, whose fluency in Malayalam led his employers to use him as an interpreter in their dealings with the rulers of Cannanore (Kannur) and Cochin (Kochi), observed that their Muslim communities were now made up of ‘Arabs, Guzaratees, Khorasanis [Afghans, Turks and Persians] and Deccanis. They are great merchants, and possess in this place wives and children, and ships for sailing to all parts of the world with all kinds of goods.’ He also observed that they had adopted the local dress code – but only to a degree: ‘They go bare like the Nairs, only they wear, to distinguish themselves from the Gentiles, small round caps on their heads, and their beards are fully grown’ (see illustration at the start of this chapter).[8]

But as the Portuguese set about securing for themselves both the spice trade and the shipping lanes, so the Pardesi element on the Malabar coast dwindled and the ancient links with Arabia were all but severed. The Portuguese also participated in the sale of Indian slaves, although not on the scale that had gone before, and their Dutch successors continued the practice. To its credit, when the East India Company took over Malabar Province in 1792 it banned the buying and selling of slaves, although the purchase of children in times of famine was exempted – and here let me raise a glass to the memory of Thomas Baber, judge and magistrate of Zillah North in Malabar, for acting against a certain Mr Murdoch Brown, who had been given permission to buy Pulliar slaves from Malabar to work on his pepper plantation in Anjarakandy on the grounds that they were already ‘by their own laws in a state of bondage’. Back in 1767 the EICo had established a cinnamon plantation in what is now Kannur District in Kerala (which is still in operation to this day). This had been leased to Mr Brown, whose treatment of his slaves became so brutal that Baber